Commonplace

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Orientation

Meaning is not a property of objects. Certain objects are meaningful to certain people, but not to others. Subjects can not generate meaning. None of us can generate meaning at will. None of us can experience meaning at will. Meaning, emerges during the right interaction between the subject and the object.

Since meaning is not a property *of* objects, there is no meaning *of* life. Since meaning emerges out of your interactions with life, there is meaning *in* your interactions with life, there is meaning *in* life.

The question "What is the meaning of life?" would have required a propositional answer, such as "The meaning of life is X." But we have seen that this is not the right question, since there is no meaning of life. Because meaning is found during interactions, the right question is "How can I interact with life such that I can experience meaning?" This question does not expect a proposition as an answer, but an interaction. Thus, we get,

The first change in orientation: from rigid ideas and abstract ideals to the lived experience.

There is no distant objective meaning of life X that you have to strive towards, but rather, each and every one of your interactions with life can either be a meaningful one or not.

> There is no way to Nirvana, Nirvana is the way.
> — Thich Nhat Hanh, "The Heart of the Buddha's Teaching"

> There is no Nirvana outside of your practice.
> — Shunryu Suzuki, "Zen Mind, Beginner's Mind"

> Neither shall they say, Lo here! or, lo there! for, behold, the kingdom of God is within you.
> — Luke 17:21, KJV

As such, with regards to meaning,

> Virtue is the only good, and vice the only evil; everything else is indifferent.
> — Seneca, "Letters to Lucilius", Letter LXXVI

Thus, paradoxically, pursuing the distant and abstract ideal of "having (what I rigidly imagine to be instead of what actually is) a meaningful life" prevents you from actually living a meaningful life. As practitioners, we don't want to live a meaningful life, we just engage in meaningful actions. From this we get,

The second change in orientation: from having (a meaningful life, a virtuous character, objects, achievements, status, desired circumstances) to engaging in the right interactions.

From attachment springs grief, from attachment springs fear. For one who is wholly free from attachment there is no grief, whence then fear?
— Dhammapada, verse 214

It is not the man who has too little, but the man who craves more, who is poor.
— Seneca, "Letters to Lucilius", Letter II

It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle than for someone who is rich to enter the kingdom of God.
— Matthew 19:24, NRSVUE

Now, because meaning emerges during interaction, living a meaningful life also involves

The third change in orientation: from self-centeredness to caring for others.

At the core of a meaningful life is the shift from "How can the world be relevant to me? How can I derive what I want from it? How can I make it fit my ideas?" to "How can I be relevant to the world? How can I be relevant to myself, to others, and to something that transcends me (e.g., a child, a form of art)?" This is a synthesis of John Vervaeke's research on meaning in life and it aligns with findings from the 80-year Harvard Study of Adult Development. As the study authors conclude:

Among Harvard Study participants, the happiest and the most satisfied adults were those who managed to turn the question "What can I do for myself?" into "What can I do for the world beyond me?"
— Robert Waldinger and Mark Schulz, "The Good Life"

All the suffering in the world comes from the desire for oneself to be happy. All the happiness in the world comes from the desire for others to be happy.
— (Dalai Lama's paraphrase of) Shantideva, "Bodhicaryāvatāra" (A Guide to the Bodhisattva's Way of Life), 8:129

No one can lead a happy life if he thinks only of himself and turns everything to his own purposes. You should live for the other person if you wish to live for yourself.
— Seneca, "Letters to Lucilius", Letter XLVIII

Whoever wishes to be great among you must be your servant, and whoever wishes to be first among you must be your slave, just as the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve and to give his life a ransom for many.
— Matthew 20:26–28, NRSVUE

Perspective

Consider how the chain of causation works using this example of a person holding a glass of water in the air:

The First Link: The glass of water has the potential to be up in the air but it actually is in the

air only because my hand actually holds it there right now. My hand has the potential to hold the glass in the air but having the potential is not enough; my hand has to *actually* hold the glass in the air.

The Second Link: My hand has the potential to hold the glass in the air, but in order to actually do so it needs my arm to actually support it right now in this position.

The Third Link: My arm has the potential to hold my hand in that position, but in order to do so it needs my shoulder to actually hold it so that it can actually hold the hand so that the glass can actually be in the air.

The General Rule: Each link borrows its actualizing power from the link above it. If at any second you were to take away any link from this chain, everything further down the chain would lose its causal power. If you take away the shoulder, the glass will fall on the ground; it will no longer be up in the air, and neither will the arm or the hand. Everything that has a potential requires a prior link to actualize that potential.

The Final Link: Because no link from the chain actually has any actualizing power, because every link just borrows it from the link above, the chain can not go indefinitely, as then there will be no actualizing power in the chain. Thus, The chain must terminate in a source of actualizing power. Subsequently, that source has to have no unactualized potential, so that it does not require a prior cause. And finally, the chains must terminate in a single source; because if there were two they would mutually limit each other and that would imply that they had unactualized potential, which would imply a prior cause (a cause that sets the rules for how they interact and limit each other). Thus, there is a single ultimate cause of everything, a single Nature of all things, the One, the Causeless Cause, the Self-Moving Mover as Plato would call it, that lends its actualizing power to the links down the causal chain, God, which is pure actuality with no unactualized potential, namely: Existence itself.

> And God said unto Moses, I AM THAT I AM: and he said, Thus shalt thou say unto the children of Israel, I AM hath sent me unto you.
> — Exodus 3:14, KJV

God actively creates us and actively grounds our very being in each and every moment we exist. Remember, if at any moment any part of the chain ceases to actively actualize the next, the whole chain from that point forward drops. God doesn't just passively exist, God currently and actively actualizes our very being. It is present within our very being during each and every moment just like the laws of physics are present within the trajectory of every falling rock at every given moment, actively creating, actively shaping that trajectory; you cannot see them, you cannot touch them, but you cannot deny their existence and their active effect. We are icons of God because God is present within us in each and every moment. God is present within each and every thing in each and every moment.

> Where can I go from your spirit? Or where can I flee from your presence? If I ascend to heaven, you are there; if I make my bed in Sheol, you are there. If I take the wings of the morning and settle at the farthest limits of the sea, even there your hand shall lead me, and your right hand shall hold me fast.
> — Psalms 139:7–10, NRSVUE

Since we are icons of God, since you can see God in each and every human being, when

> the righteous will answer him, "Lord, when did we see you hungry and feed you, or thirsty and give you something to drink? When did we see you a stranger and invite you in, or needing clothes and clothe you? When did we see you sick or in prison and go to visit you?"
> The King will reply, "Truly I tell you, whatever you did for one of the least of these brothers and sisters of mine, you did for me."
> — Matthew 25:37–40, NIV

Thus, the meaningful life can be summarized in a single sentence:

> Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength and with all your mind and your neighbor as yourself.
> — Luke 10:27, NRSVUE

Since both you and your neighbor are children of God and icons of God;

> or do you not know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit within you, which you have from God, and that you are not your own? For you were bought with a price; therefore glorify God in your body.
> — 1 Corinthians 6:19, NRSVUE

However, it is important to remember that, while God is present within you and within your neighbor, neither you nor your neighbor are God. A priest once told me that "God sees me through you and sees you through me but neither of us are God". God is fully immanent and fully transcendent at the same time. While God is present within every thing, God is not any particular thing.

That which grounds and explains all things is not itself any particular thing; just like the laws of nature that cause and explain the trajectory of every fall rock are not themselves a trajectory of a falling rock. That which grounds and explains all beings is not a(ny) being. Aside from God not being any thing, to take things even further, nothing affirmative can ever be said about God. That which grounds and explains both the finite and the infinite is neither finite nor infinite; it is the source of both the finite and the infinite. That which grounds and explains both the good and the bad is neither good nor bad; it lives beyond them. Every idea we have about God is wrong. Even imagining God as a cause is wrong; the cause of all causes is not itself a cause.

> You cannot see my face, for no one shall see me and live.
> — Exodus 33:20, NRSVUE

Nothing that exists can perceive God; that which grounds and explains all things that exists is not a thing that exists and that we can perceive, God is beyond existence. Capital "E" Existence itself is not existence (as in the things that exist); it is that which grounds and explains all of existence. Thus, every idea that exists in your mind about God is wrong, and if you serve it you are only serving your own intellect; you miss out the real God and you end up in spiritual death. Therefore,

> you shall not make for yourself an idol, whether in the form of anything that is in heaven above or that is on the earth beneath or that is in the water under the earth. You shall not bow down to them or serve them.
> — Exodus 20:4–5, NRSVUE

Practice

> Now as they went on their way, he entered a certain village where a woman named Martha welcomed him. She had a sister named Mary, who sat at Jesus's feet and listened to what he was saying. But Martha was distracted by her many tasks, so she came to him and asked, "Lord, do you not care that my sister has left me to do all the work by myself? Tell her, then, to help me." But the Lord answered her, "Martha, Martha, you are worried and distracted by many things, but few things are needed—indeed only one. Mary has chosen the better part, which will not be taken away from her."
> — Luke 10:38–42, NRSVUE

Placing yourself at God's feet in a state of adoration is the only thing that is required for a meaningful life. Once you develop your love for God, and you start to see God in yourself and others, the natural result is the manifestation of that love in the form of serving the other. Notice how this service is not a means to an end but rather it is an end itself. The manifestation of your love of God in the form on serving your neighbor is the meaningful life being fully lived right now. It is the enacted answer to the question "What can I do for the world beyond me?" from the 80-year Harvard Study of Adult Development and from Dr. John Vervaeke's research on meaning in life.

But how do you place yourself at God's feet?

> If You would have desired sacrifice, I would have given it; You will not find whole-burnt offerings acceptable. A sacrifice acceptable to God: the spirit that lives with humility. A shattered and humble heart God will not cast away.
> — Psalms 50:17–18, personal translation based on the version from the Romanian Eastern Orthodox Bible

I have chosen to use a personal translation because all the English versions I have found employed the legalistic framing that is common in the West rather than the therapeutic framing of Eastern Orthodoxy. Eastern Orthodoxy is therapeutic in the same way in which dialogues with Socrates were. When people came with a fixed idea about what is good, Socrates shattered that idea through questioning, humbling them and planting a seed of intellectual humility in them which opens them up. An encounter with Socrates is a liberating experience that shatters an idol and frees you. In the same way, the Eastern Orthodox way of life, which, at its core, among other things, is about letting go of cravings, is therapeutic because it frees you from the tyranny of the craving; because it shatters the idol that compels you, it shatters the idol that you are serving and frees you up.

Thus, the answer to the question "How do you place yourself at God's feet?" is: first and foremost, by untying yourself from the cravings that constantly pull you away towards one direction or another; that do not allow you to sit. You being to sit at God's feet by shattering all the idols that you are serving and opening yourself up to Existence. This is also the mechanism which opens you up to seeing the other as an icon of God. If you crave status, what you see when you look at the other is as either a tool that can increase your status or an obstacle in your path towards status; when you crave status, you see yourself as a tool or an obstacle in the path towards status, not a person, not a child of God.

One of the main practices that focus on letting go of cravings is fasting. Not just fasting from food, but in general. To give a few examples, Athonite monks have virtually no material possessions, they only dress in simple black clothing, they live in simple huts, they barely sleep, they barely eat, they engage in grueling and unpleasant work, untying themselves from craving comfort, and

they submit themselves completely to the will of the abbot, untying themselves from the craving to manifest their will. At the monastery, under the instruction of his abbot, Saint John of Damascus, who arrived as a prolific writer, gave up writing for several years, performed menial tasks instead and even engaged in cleaning the latrines when instructed to do so. Furthermore, monks never praise themselves on their work, nor do they ever receive praise, not even for spiritual work. After sixty years of extreme asceticism, on his deathbed, Saint Sisoes the Great, said to his disciples: "Truly, I do not consider that I have began to lay my spiritual foundation." The spiritual mentor might tell monks to throw away their work after finishing it in order to teach them not to crave outcomes. The abbot of Saint John of Damascus had him weave baskets and then try to sell them at enormous prices, so that none of his works would get bought and that he would receive ridicule from people.

They even keep their craving for prayer under control. If they crave prayer, their spiritual mentor will even forbid them from praying, limiting their prayer time to 5 minutes a day. Eastern Orthodox Christianity is all about prayer, yet an Orthodox Christian monk, who is now a famous abbot in Romania, had his prayer time limited to 5 minutes a day for 4 years by his abbot. You must unchain yourself even from the craving for the outcomes of prayer (which may be about the feeling you get when you pray or about the pride you feel because you think you are making spiritual progress) in order to pray properly. Fasting prepares us for proper prayer.

Another example that I really like is Saint Maximos the Hut-Burner of Mount Athos. He lived as a hermit and built his huts from branches and leaves. And whenever he would feel like he made progress in one place, when people found out where he lived and started to visit him and praise his asceticism, he burned his hut and moved deeper into the woods in order to stay away from spiritual pride. At some point he even started acting mad so that people would drop their praises for him. And it worked, people thought he was possessed, avoided him and ridiculed him. However, when Saint Gregory of Sinai came to talk to him, he spoke very eloquently, with profound theological clarity. Then, Saint Gregory asked him to remain in one place so that people could benefit from his counsel, and he did, dropping his hut-burning practice. I love Saint Maximos Kausokalybites' example because he unchained himself from the craving for spiritual progress, and then he unchained himself of the craving to unchain himself of the craving for spiritual progress. The craving to not have any craving is still a craving. One should fast even from fasting. The Orthodox calendar alternates between fasting and feasting; on average, the year is divided roughly half-half. If you feel like you are *running* towards something or away from something, then you are not *sitting* at God's feet; fasting is the practice that allows you to rest.

> Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy and my burden is light.
> — Matthew 11:28–30, NIV

Once we start shattering idols through fasting we can also start orienting ourselves towards God through prayer. Once we start sitting, we can start sitting *at God's feet*.

> Some take pride in chariots and some in horses, but our pride is in the name of the LORD our God.
> — Psalms 20:7, NRSVUE

There are many ways of praying, but there are three prayers that in some sense sit at the foundation of Eastern Orthodox Christianity. These are: "Glory to God for all things", "Lord, have mercy" and "Not my will, but Thy will be done".

I love these prayers because they are not transactional and because in some sense they span the full range of prayer. "Glory to God for all things" is purely about orientation, awe and appreciation. "Lord, have mercy" is an open-ended petition; we do not expect anything specifically. When we pray "Lord, have mercy" we do not aim at changing God's mind, rather, we orient towards God while acknowledging our dependence upon God's mercy; while acknowledging our finitude. The third prayer can be a petitionary prayer, but the petition is formulated the way Jesus did: "Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me, yet not my will but yours be done" (Luke 22:42, NRSVUE). This form combines both commitment and acceptance: you pray for something in order to orient yourself and to commit yourself to a course of action while at the same time accepting that the outcome of your actions is not for you to decide; without craving a specific outcome. With these three prayers: (i) you praise God, (ii) you acknowledge your dependence upon God and (iii) you align your will to God's will. These prayers are not transactional because we do not expect anything specifically, the prayers are complete in themselves, they are expressions of our continued orientation toward God.

Adapt these prayers throughout the day. Remember God's presence (Psalms 139:7–10), praise God, not in general but for the particular things that you notice throughout the day, ask God for mercy, ask God for something and then work towards that end, serve knowing that God is present with-ing you and within the other, work as you would work for God, without craving an outcome, while entrusting the outcome to God. This is the meaningful life fully lived in the very moment; the yoke of God is that of manifesting the goodness of your heart through acts of caring that provide meaning, without the burden of the cravings. Talk to God all the time and serve God all the time. The saints did not pray from time to time, but rather, they lived prayerful lives; they always lived in communion with God.

> We must remember God more often than we draw breath.
> — St. Gregory of Nazianzus, Orat. theo., 27, 1, 4: PG 36, 16

With regards to this quote, Athonite monks pray the Jesus prayer, "Lord Jesus Christ, son of God, have mercy on me a sinner" for extended periods of time throughout the day. They might just whisper it while counting the repetitions using beads. They might count the repetitions with their left hand, make the sign of the cross and then bow from their hips reaching towards the ground with their right hand, and then return to the standing position during each repetition. They might even synchronize mental repetitions of the prayer with their breath; half during the inhale and half during the exhale. Lay Eastern Orthodox Christians are generally encouraged to pursue any such form of prayer whenever they are able to throughout the day.

In a sense, prayer can also teach us how to fast. When you dedicate time to prayer, when a thought comes, you do not entertain it, otherwise you are thinking about something else, you are not praying. Neither are you running away from it or wrestling with it, because then you are running from your thoughts or wrestling with your thoughts, not praying. When you pray and a thought comes, you simply let it be (you let it run in the background) and continue praying. If your mind wanders and you realize that, you return to praying, spending no more time on something else. You let your attachment to the thought (or to the thought of wanting the thought gone) go, you untie yourself from the thought, and you continue praying. Fasting is like this, but with your whole being. You don't fight your cravings, that would be exhausting, they never end. You don't endorse them either. You simply live your life while letting go of them, while untying yourself from them. You let them be, you let them come and go, and you live your life in peace; and you learn how to let go by praying actively, constantly returning to your prayer instead of

entertaining, fighting or running.

Fasting and prayer are the practices that, when practiced within the larger Eastern Orthodox ecosystem, allow us to place ourselves at God's feet like Mary did. They enable us to enter in a communion with God, and they enable us to see ourselves and others as icons of God and children of God; they enable us to develop a charitable heart.

> What is a charitable [merciful] heart? It is a heart which is burning with love for the whole creation, for men, for the birds, for the beasts, for the demons—for all creatures. When a man with such a heart as this thinks of the creatures and looks at them, his eyes are filled with tears because of the overwhelming compassion that presses upon his heart; a heart such as this grows tender and can no longer bear to see or learn from others of any suffering, even the smallest pain being inflicted upon a creature. Therefore he never ceases to pray with tears even for the dumb animals, for the enemies of truth, and for all who do harm to it, asking that they may be guarded and receive God's mercy. And for the reptiles also he prays with a great compassion, which rises up endlessly in his heart, after the example of God.
> — Saint Isaac the Syrian, "Ascetical Homilies", HTM Homily 71, p. 491

And what is God's example?

> I came that they may have life and have it abundantly. I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep. [...] No one takes it from me, but I lay it down of my own accord.
> — John 10:10-18, NRSVUE

To the best of my understanding, to the man with a charitable heart, who sees God present in himself and the other, charity is not a sacrifice, rather, it is the most meaningful thing one can do; the man with a charitable heart engages in self-emptying acts of love willingly, like God exemplified.

> For people do not gather figs from thorns, nor do they pick grapes from a bramble bush. The good person out of the good treasure of the heart produces good, and the evil person out of evil treasure produces evil, for it is out of the abundance of the heart that the mouth speaks.
> — Luke 6:44–45, NRSVUE

I have written this text so that I can easily recall and easily return to the core ideas. However, a meaningful life is something that is lived, and a way of life cannot be captured by a text. A way of life is learned by being immersed in a community which practices a living tradition and it is expressed by active participation within the community. First, the community offers correction. You can only see things *through* your perspective. You need another individual, who can look *at* at your perspective rather than *through* it, in order to show you its holes so that you can transcend them. And second, the community offers you the opportunity to participate in this way of life with your whole being. Within the community there's music, there's imagery, certain smells, rituals, a certain way of speaking and relating to one another, an entire calendar specifically designed for the tradition, an entire story that people relive together, an entire lineage that you connect to, an entire ecology of interconnected practices. In is by participating in this way of life with your whole being, together with the whole community, that you can start to enter into a communion with God.

Selection of Resources

— The Death of Ivan Ilych — Leo Tolstoy

— How God Changes Your Brain — Andrew Newberg and Mark Robert Waldman

— Get Out of Your Mind and Into Your Life — Steven C. Hayes

— Trauma-Focused ACT — Russ Harris

— Superforecasting — Philip Tetlock and Dan Gardner

— The Good Life — Robert Waldinger and Mark Schulz

— What is Ancient Philosophy? — Pierre Hadot

— Opening the Hand of Thought — Kosho Uchiyama

— Living by Vow — Shohaku Okumura

— The Inner Citadel — Pierre Hadot

— The Wisdom of Hypatia — Bruce J. MacLennan

— John Vervaeke — Awakening from the Meaning Crisis

— John Vervaeke — After Socrates

— John Vervaeke — The God of Einstein and Spinoza

— Dialectic and Dialogue: Plato's Practice of Philosophical Inquiry — Francisco J. Gonzales

— Plato — Complete Works

— Diogenes the Cynic: Sayings and Anecdotes, With Other Popular Moralists — Oxford World's Classics — translated by Robin Hard

— Letters from a Stoic — Seneca — Penguin Classics

— Meditations — Marcus Aurelius — Penguin Classics

— Discourses and Selected Writings — Epictetus — Penguin Classics